

The Handmaid's Tale: A Complete Guide

Author background • Introduction to the novel • Critical commentary • Literary analysis



CHAPTER 1

Author Background

Who is Margaret Atwood, and why did she write this novel?



Margaret Atwood: Who Is She?

- Born Ottawa, Canada, 18 November 1939; spent early childhood on research expeditions in the Canadian wilderness with her entomologist father
- Studied at Victoria College, University of Toronto (1961) and Radcliffe College, Harvard (1962)
- Prolific author of novels, poetry, short fiction, graphic novels, children's books, and scripts
- Won the Booker Prize twice: *The Blind Assassin* (2000) and *The Testaments* (2020, shared)

What Inspired *The Handmaid's Tale*?

Berlin, 1984

Atwood began writing the novel amid the rise of the religious right under Ronald Reagan and rhetoric that "women belong in the home."

The Golden Rule

Nothing in the novel that didn't happen somewhere — every law and social practice has a real-world precedent in history.

The Central Question

"If you wanted to seize power in the United States, how would you go about it?"

The Dedication

Dedicated to Mary Webster — a woman accused of witchcraft in 1680s Massachusetts who survived her hanging, a "symbol of hope."



Atwood's Key Views on Power & Gender

“

On Dictatorships

"No repressive regime ever comes in by saying, 'Hi folks, I'm a repressive regime.' They always say, 'The country is a real mess, and we're going to help.'"

”

“

On Feminism

Atwood resists the idea that women are "Victorian angels" — in Gilead, the Aunts control the Handmaids, showing how power structures use women against each other.

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“

On Religion

"You can use any religion as an excuse for being repressive, and any religion as an excuse for resisting repression — it works both ways."

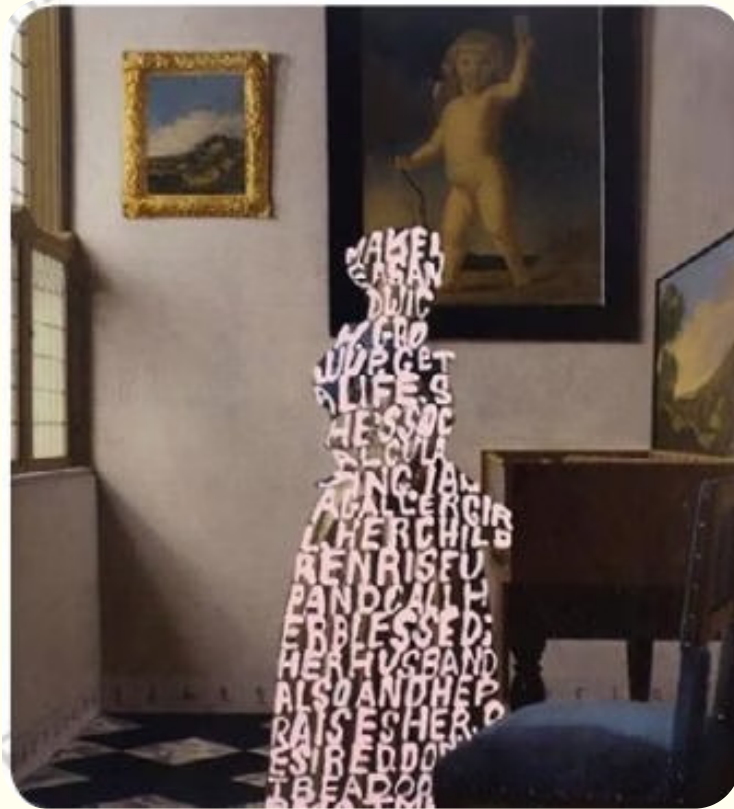
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CHAPTER 2

Introduction to the Novel

The world of Gilead, its people, and its opening scenes.

The World of Gilead



Setting

A near-future theocratic dictatorship built on the ruins of the United States, governed by a strict interpretation of the Old Testament.

Social Structure

A rigid pyramid — **Commanders** at the top, then Wives, Aunts, Marthas, Handmaids, and Econowives at the base.

Core Crisis

Plummeting fertility rates in the industrialised West. Fertile women — the Handmaids — become the regime's most prized *and* most controlled resource.

Offred: The Protagonist

- A Handmaid assigned to a Commander — her name literally means "**Of Fred**", erasing her individual identity
- Her real name is never confirmed in the novel; she whispers it to herself as an act of private resistance
- Narrates from memory, making her account subjective and unreliable — she admits: "*I compose myself*"
- Her red dress signals fertility; her white wings restrict her vision, symbolising the regime's control over what women can see and know





Opening Chapter: A Gymnasium Turned Prison

The Setting

A school gymnasium repurposed as a dormitory — army cots in rows, Aunts patrolling with electric cattle prods.

The Contrast

Past (basketball games, school dances, "*we yearned for the future*") vs. present (barbed wire, silence, no names).

The Act of Defiance

Women secretly stretch toward each other and whisper names: "*Alma. Janine. Dolores. Moira. June*" — resisting erasure one syllable at a time.

CHAPTER 3

Critical Commentary

Historical roots and methods of reading for meaning and form.

Historical Roots of Gilead



Nazi Lebensborn Programme (1935)

SS recruited "racially pure" women to bear children for officers. Around 20,000 babies were bred; thousands of foreign children were abducted and placed with German families.



Puritan New England

Gilead's theocracy mirrors the original Puritan colonies — a selective use of scripture to justify social control over bodies, labour, and conscience.



20th-Century Dictatorships

Atwood drew on Argentina, the Philippines ("salvaging"), and the USSR — all regimes that used propaganda, secret police, and public executions.

Reading for Meaning and Form

Patterns of Meaning — *What*

How is the plot structured? What are the recurring themes? What message is Atwood conveying about power, gender, and freedom?

- ❑ Literary analysis means detecting patterns — not just summarising events, but asking **why** Atwood made each narrative choice.

Patterns of Form — *How*

Who narrates, and when? Is the narration sequential or achronological? What symbols and motifs recur across chapters?

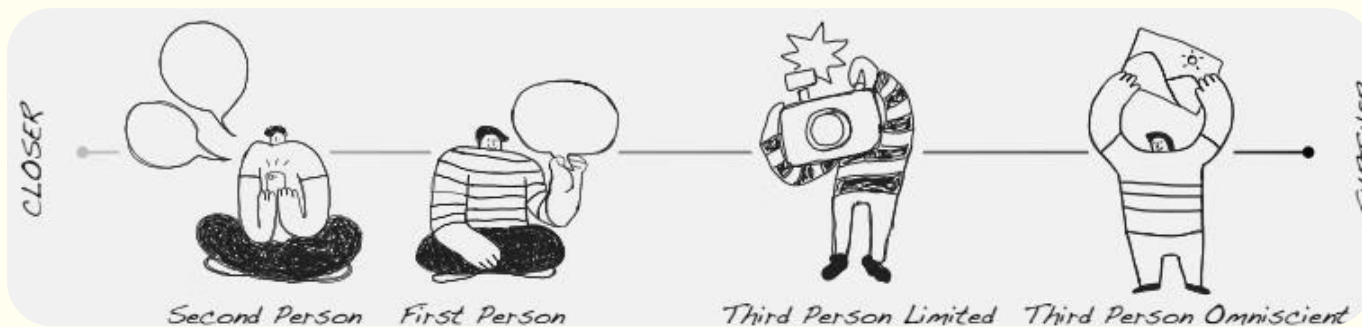
- Narrative voice (first-person, unreliable)
- Non-linear structure and flashbacks
- Recurring symbols (red, the Wall, the garden)
- The "Historical Notes" epilogue as framing device

CHAPTER 4

Literary Analysis

Narrative style, key themes, and the symbols that carry Atwood's meaning.

Narrative Style: First-Person & Non-Linear



- Told in **first-person** by Offred — creates intimacy and implicates the reader, but also limits what we know
- **Non-linear structure:** Flashbacks to life before Gilead interrupt the present narrative, showing what has been lost and why it matters
- Atwood frames the novel as a **found tape recording** — raising questions about truth, memory, and who controls the story

"I compose myself."

— Offred, both literally and metaphorically

Key Themes



Power & Control

Gilead controls bodies, language, movement, and reproduction through the Eyes, the Wall, and the Red Centre's indoctrination.



Identity & Resistance

Offred preserves her sense of self through memory, storytelling, and secret acts — small rebellions against total erasure.



Gender & Complicity

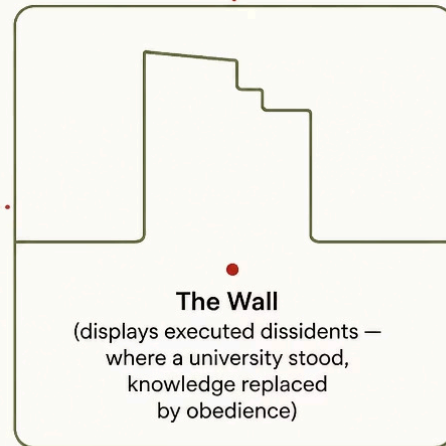
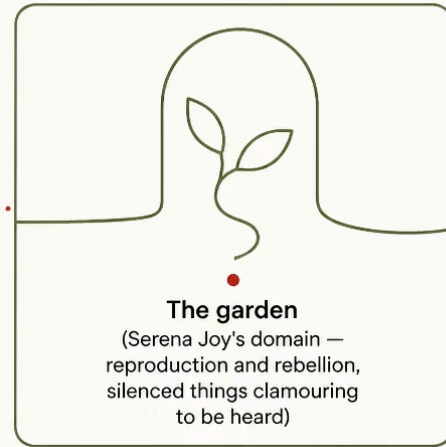
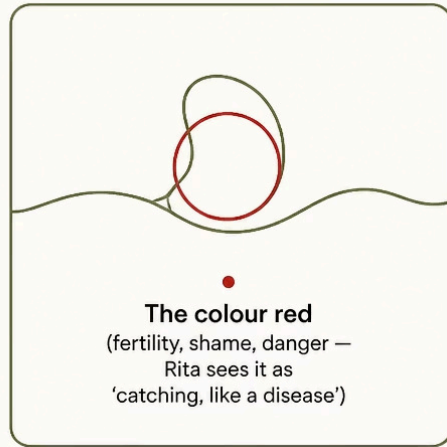
Women are divided against each other — Wives, Aunts, and Marthas each hold different degrees of power over Handmaids.



Religion & Ideology

Gilead weaponises scripture. Atwood shows how any belief system can be manipulated to serve political ends.

Symbolism: Red, the Garden & the Eyes



The Colour Red

Signals fertility (blood, menstruation, childbirth) but also shame and danger. Rita sees the red dress as *"catching, like a disease."*

The Garden

Serena Joy's domain — a symbol of both reproduction and rebellion. *"Whatever is silenced will clamour to be heard, though silently."*

The Eyes

Gilead's secret police — surveillance as a tool of terror. The plastered ceiling in Offred's room becomes a haunting reminder of her predecessor's fate.

The Wall

Displays executed dissidents. Where a university once stood, knowledge has been replaced by obedience.



The Novel's Importance

"Nothing makes me more nervous than people who say, 'It can't happen here.' Anything can happen anywhere, given the right circumstances."

— Margaret Atwood

→ Banned, Adapted, Protested

The novel has been banned, adapted for film (1990) and Hulu (2017–), and worn as protest costume at legislative hearings worldwide.

→ A Structural Warning

"Once any democracy starts curtailing freedom in the name of freedom, it may land us in trouble." — Atwood's warning is political, not partisan.

→ Grade 12 Exam Focus

Track how Atwood uses **form** (narrative voice, symbolism, non-linear structure) to make her themes *felt*, not just understood.